

Kai Gu

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Education

Bocconi University PhD in Marketing	Milan, Italy 2026 – Present
Bocconi University MSc in Data Science	Milan, Italy 2024 – 2026
Zhejiang University BEcon in Economics	Hangzhou, China 2020 – 2024

Research Interests

Substantive: Economics of AI, Economics of Digitization & Platforms, Media Economics

Methodological: Causal Inference, Computational Social Sciences, Multimodal Data

Working Papers

Answering Without Referring: How AI Search Rewrites the Web's Economic Bargain

Qiaoni Shi, Kai Zhu, and Kai Gu

Presented at: Bocconi Marketing Research Camp, May 2026; ISMS Marketing Science Conference, Lisbon, Portugal, June 2026

Search engines have long allocated attention on the web by routing users from queries to websites. AI search changes this arrangement because information needs can be resolved inside the intermediary. Using URL-level Comscore U.S. desktop clickstream, we compare ChatGPT and Google information-seeking occasions and exploit ChatGPT Search access expansions to estimate traditional search displacement. ChatGPT produces outbound clicks in only 5.2% of conversation sessions, far below Google's referral ratio. The remaining clicks are not a scaled-down Google stream: they skew toward specialized destinations and away from ad-supported sites. Wider access cuts search use by 9.4%, with search-referral losses largest for informational categories. Our findings identify a central economic shift in digital intermediation: AI search might satisfy information needs inside the intermediary while weakening the referral bargain that has linked search, traffic, and content production on the open web.

Governing AI Content Tools: The Efficiency–Diversity Trade-off in Platform Knowledge Ecosystems

Kai Zhu, Kai Gu, and Lorenzo Lupo

Presented at: 13th Wiki Workshop (Online), March 2026

Conference Presentations

<i>ISMS Marketing Science Conference</i> , Lisbon, Portugal	June 2026
<i>Bocconi Marketing Research Camp</i>	May 2026
<i>13th Wiki Workshop (Online)</i>	March 2026

Skills

Languages: English, Mandarin

Programming: R, Python, L^AT_EX, Markdown